

DevGAMM FTW! Belgrade, September 29, 2026

\$150 to \$2,500 a Day

The Five Rules

Alex Wiserax, Senior Game Designer, Codigames

Economies for games that have made over \$150M

Dev
GAMM!

FTW!

Why do we make games?

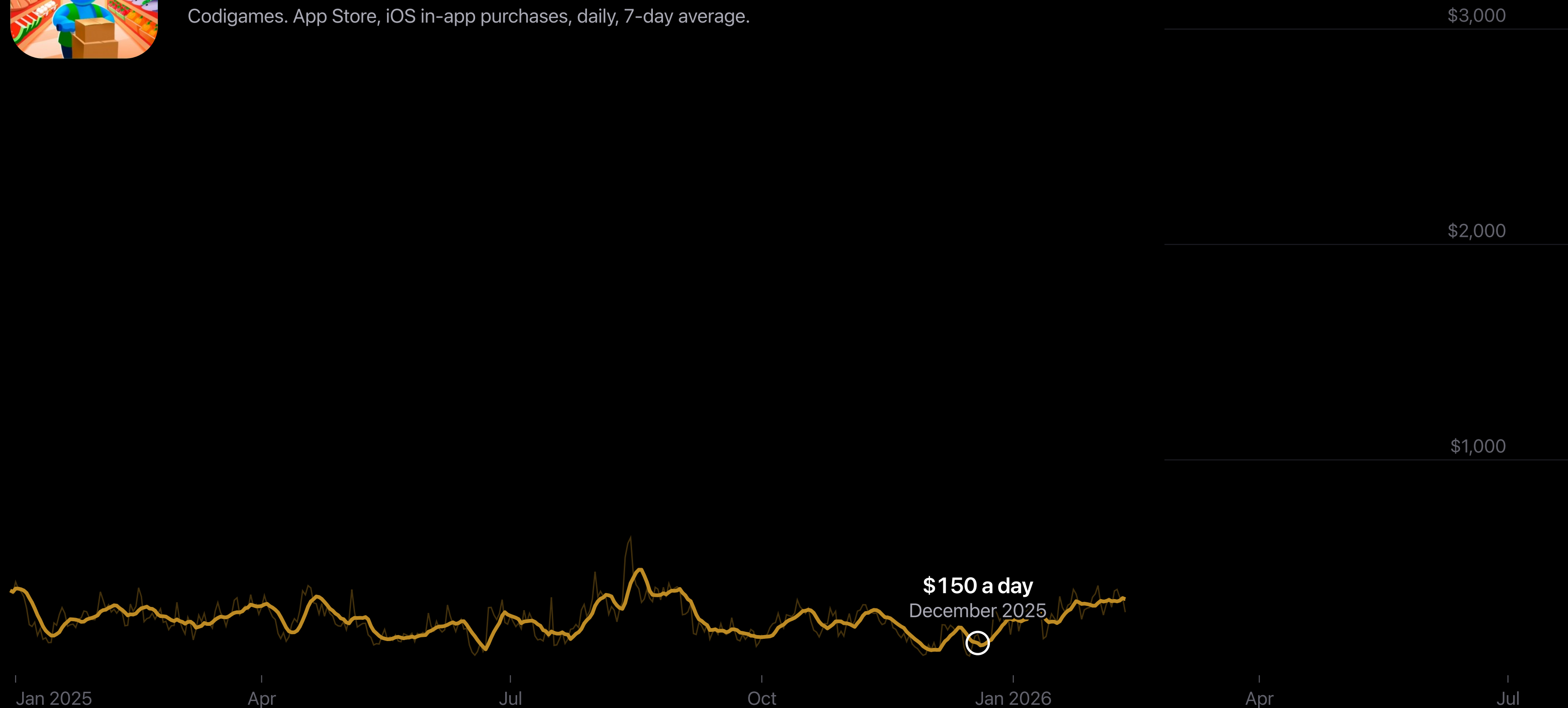
Why do we make games?

**The game has to pay back the years we put into it,
so we get to create that one masterpiece.**



Idle Supermarket Tycoon

Codigames. App Store, iOS in-app purchases, daily, 7-day average.





Idle Supermarket Tycoon

Codigames. App Store, iOS in-app purchases, daily, 7-day average.

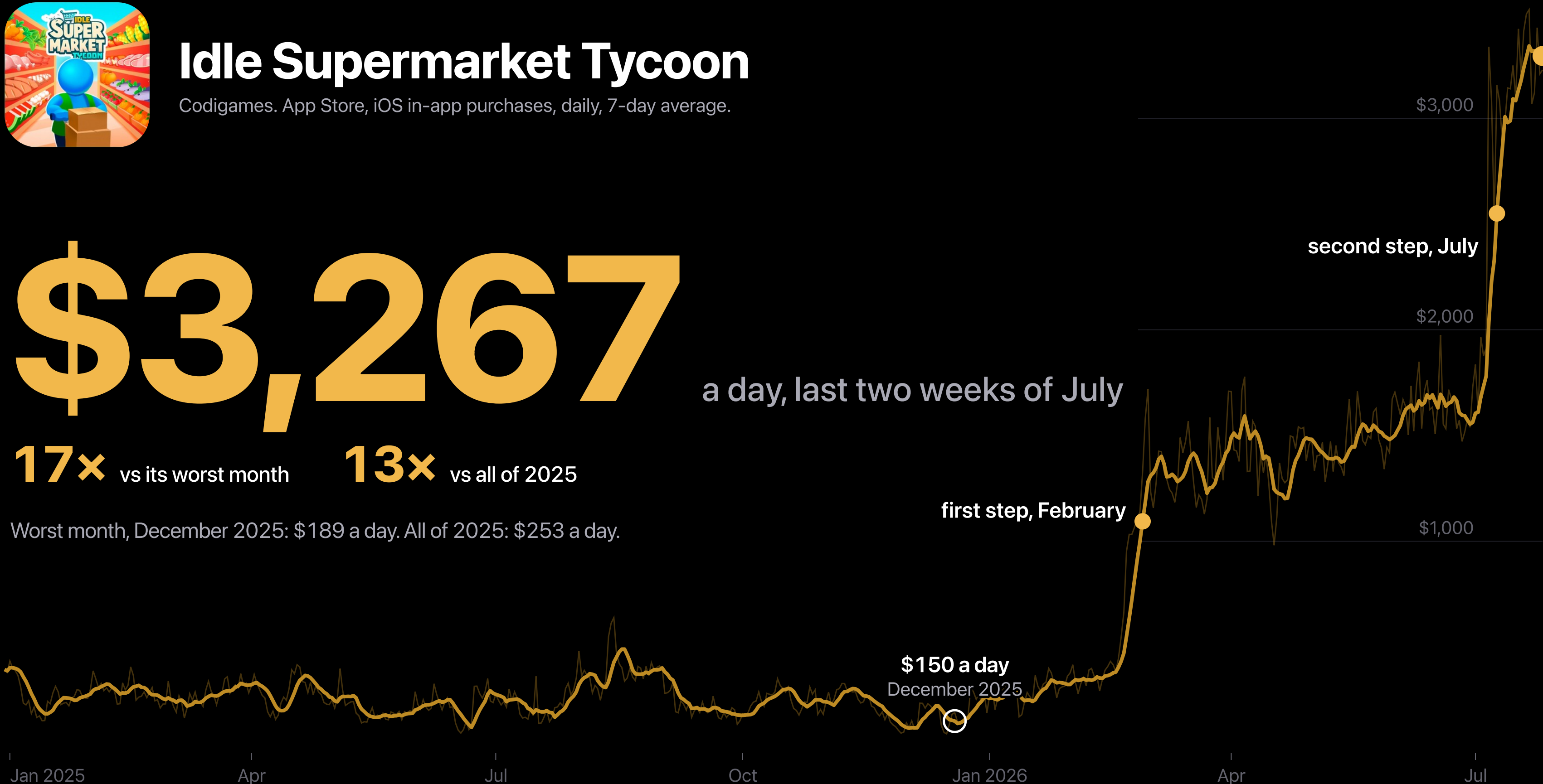
\$3,267

a day, last two weeks of July

17x vs its worst month

13x vs all of 2025

Worst month, December 2025: \$189 a day. All of 2025: \$253 a day.





Idle Theme Park

Team result. One year. Most of the experiments failed.





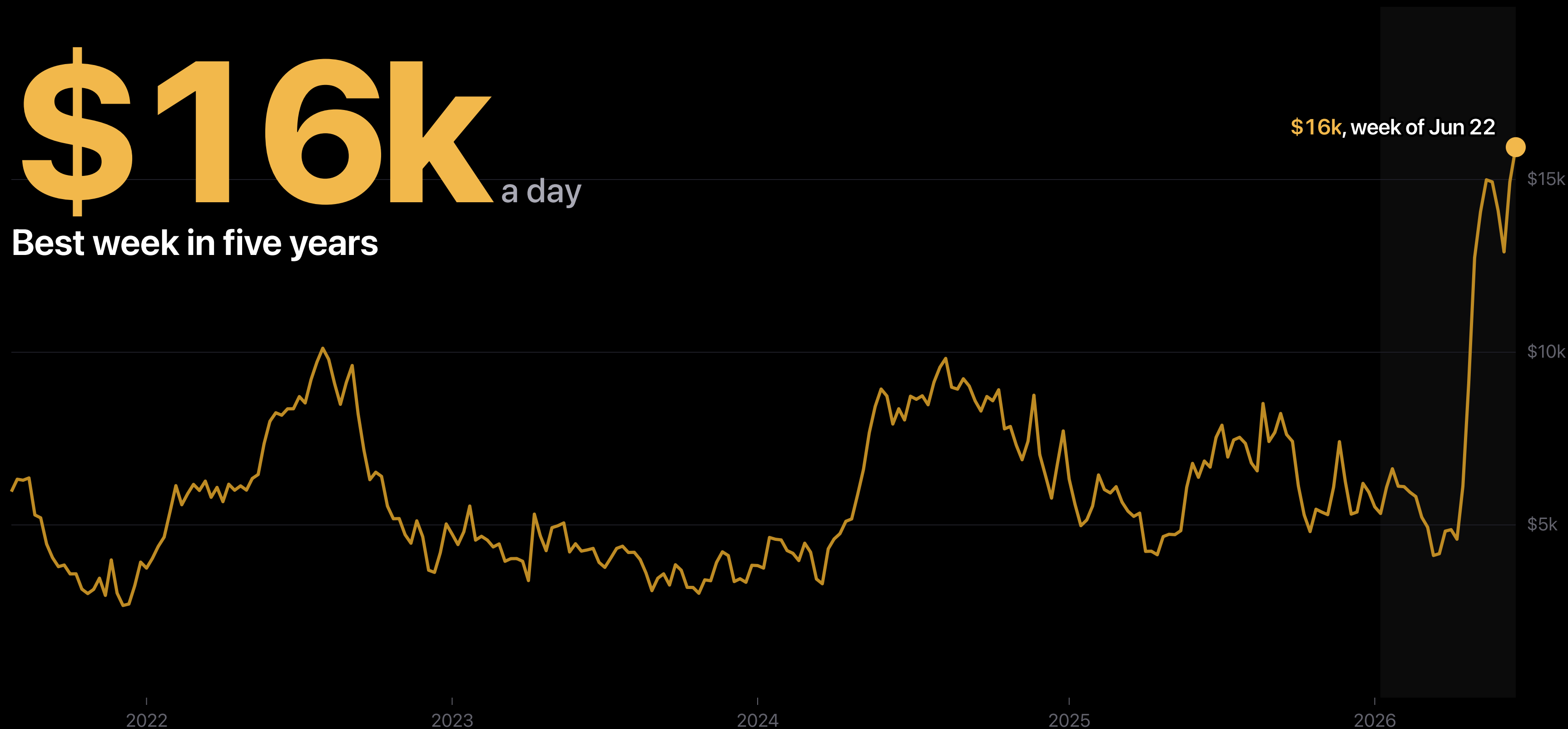
Idle Theme Park

Team result. One year. Most of the experiments failed.

\$16k

a day

Best week in five years



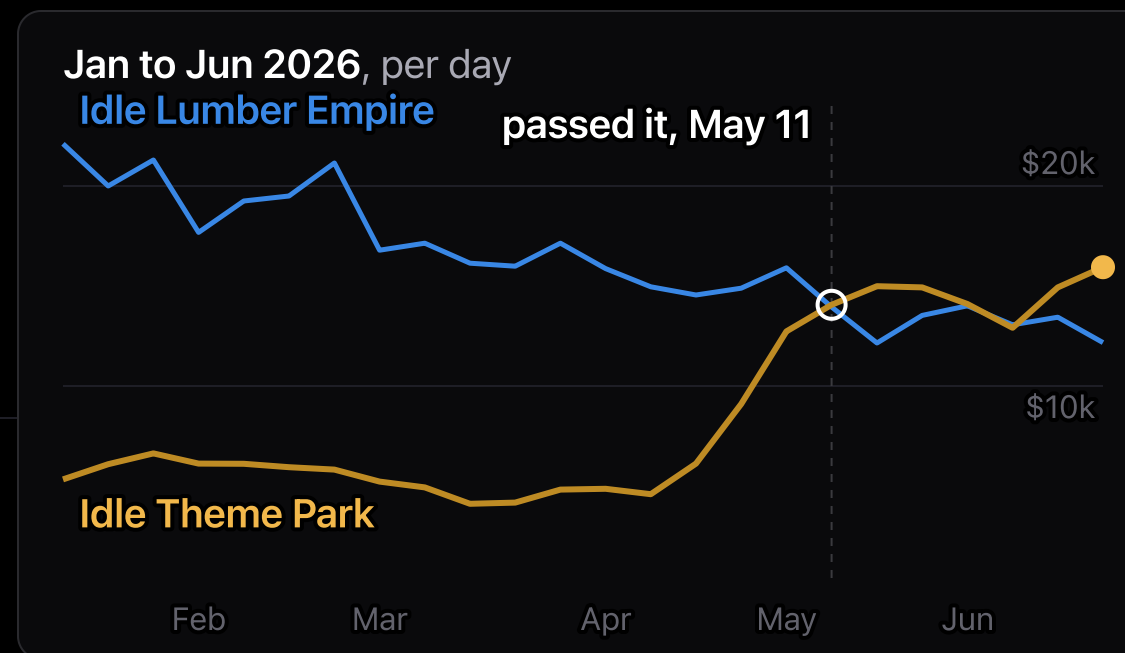
Sensor Tower, public data. Codigames, App Store, iOS in-app purchases, weekly, shown per day, Jul 2021 to Jun 2026.



Idle Theme Park

Team result. One year. Most of the experiments failed.

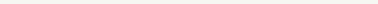
\$16k a day
Best week in five years



Release notes, v2.14.0

Internal. Do not distribute.

Added

Rebalanced 

Price of XXXXXXXXXX

Revenue

Conversion XXXXXXXXXX

What I cannot show you:

exactly what we shipped.

What I can show you:

why it worked.

- 1 Price everything in time**
- 2 Goal before monetization**
- 3 Friction must open doors**
- 4 Kill inflation before it kills you**
- 5 Basics of monetization**

From free-to-play. Useful for premium too.

Rule 1

Price everything in time



time to acquire = **cost ÷ income per hour**

energy refill, 50 coins **0.5 h**

shelf upgrade, 300 coins **3 h**

new building, 600 coins **6 h**

sword, 1,000 coins **10 h**

at 100 coins an hour. Now they can be ranked.

Rule 1

Price everything in time



time to acquire = **cost ÷ income per hour**

energy refill, 50 coins **0.5 h**

shelf upgrade, 300 coins **3 h**

new building, 600 coins **6 h**

sword, 1,000 coins **10 h**

at 100 coins an hour. Now they can be ranked.

\$4.99 → 500 gems → 5 hours

five dollars for five hours of somebody's life

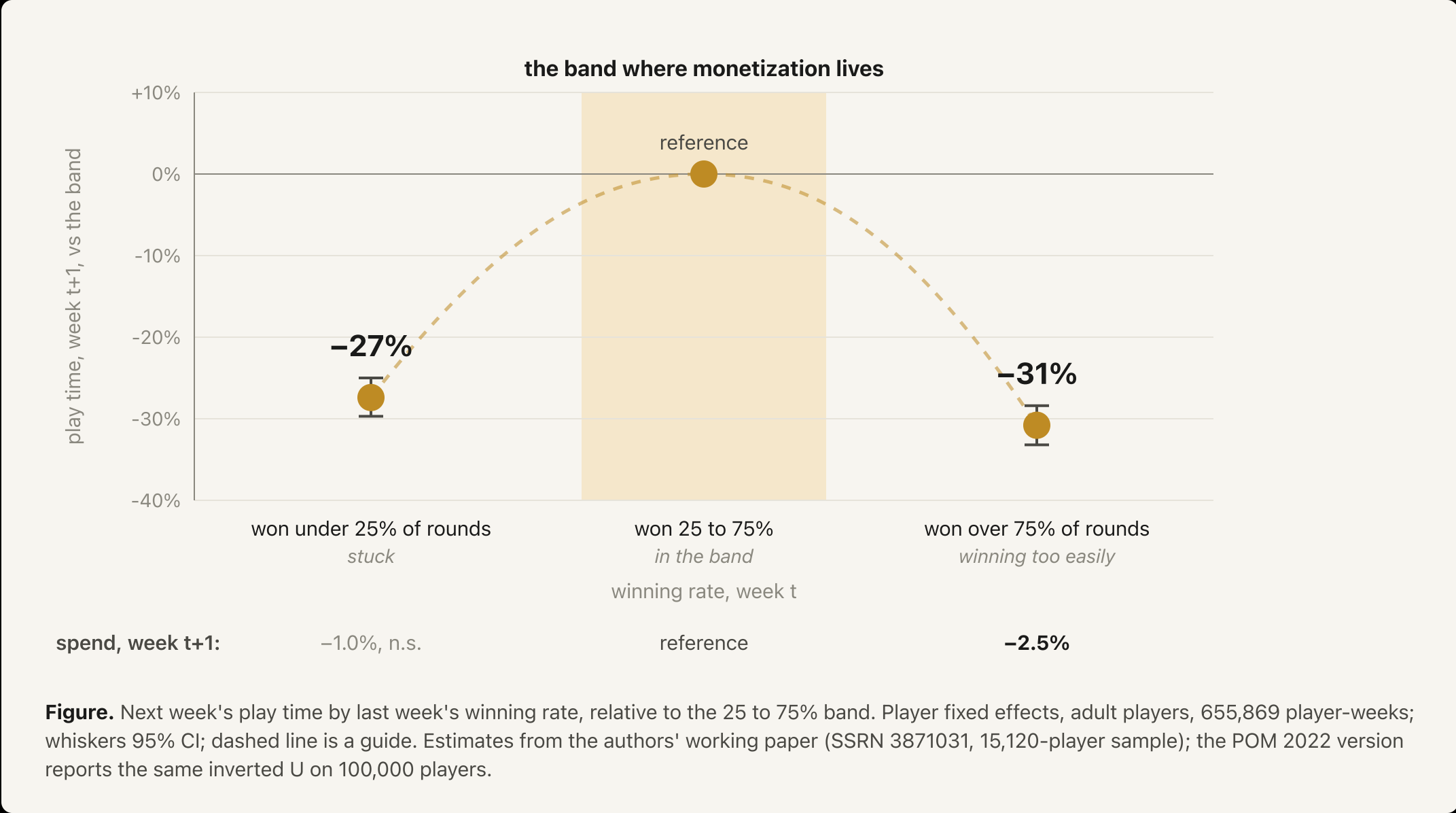
Goal before monetization

Nobody buys a shortcut to nowhere.

Jiao, Tang & Wang. Production and Operations Management, 31(9), 2022.

100,000 players tracked for three years. Performance follows an **inverted U**: winning too easily and being stuck both cut next week's play **and** next week's spend.

Difficulty is time to goal. This is rule one's curve with the price hidden inside it.



Friction must open doors

YOUR TURN

0

Fuck You All



LEGENDARY SPELL

You win the game.

“Balanced by the monetization team.”

Friction must open doors

YOUR TURN

0

Fuck You All



LEGENDARY SPELL

You win the game.

“Balanced by the monetization team.”

QUESTION 7 OF 10

0:09

$2x^2 + 4x - 4 = 0$

Tap the right answer

A

$x = -1 \pm \sqrt{3}$

B

$x = -1 \pm \sqrt{3}$

C

$x = -1 \pm \sqrt{3}$

Streak 6

50/50 lifeline

Friction must open doors

YOUR TURN

0

Fuck You All



LEGENDARY SPELL

You win the game.

"Balanced by the monetization team."

One decides everything.
One decides nothing.

EVERY FRICTION POINT YOU SHIP LIVES HERE

QUESTION 7 OF 10

0:09

$2x^2 + 4x - 4 = 0$

Tap the right answer

A

$x = -1 \pm \sqrt{3}$

B

$x = -1 \pm \sqrt{3}$

C

$x = -1 \pm \sqrt{3}$

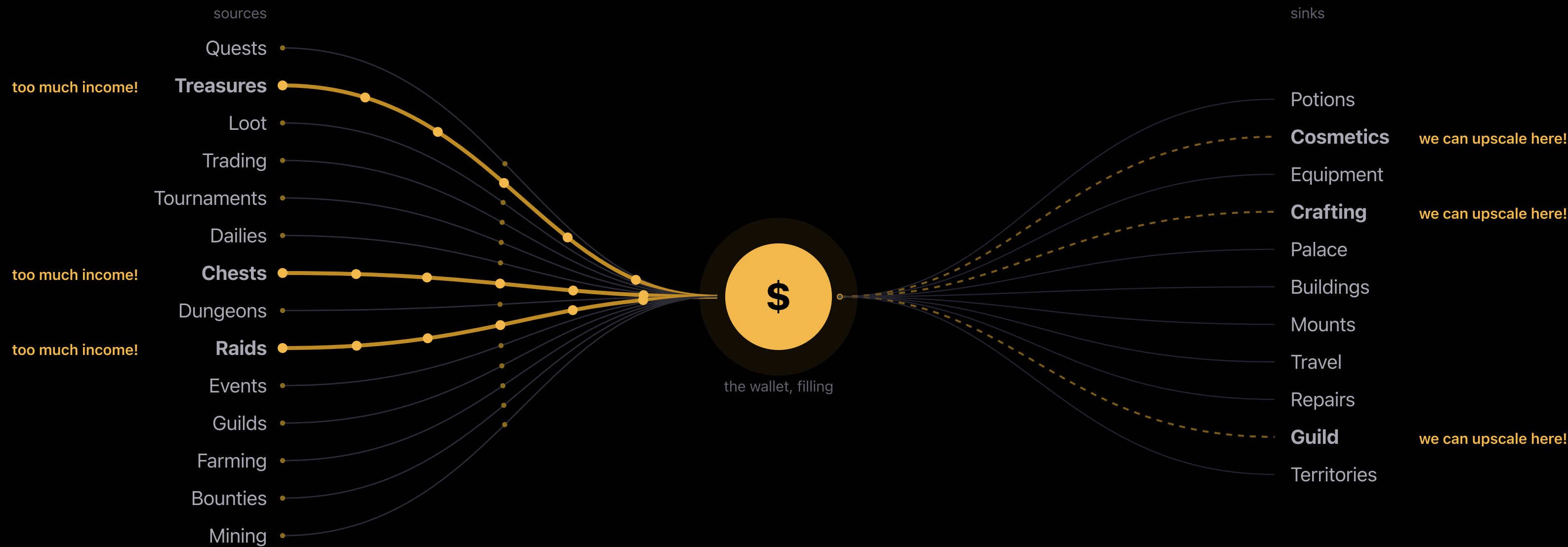
Streak 6

50/50 lifeline

Rule 4

Kill inflation before it kills you

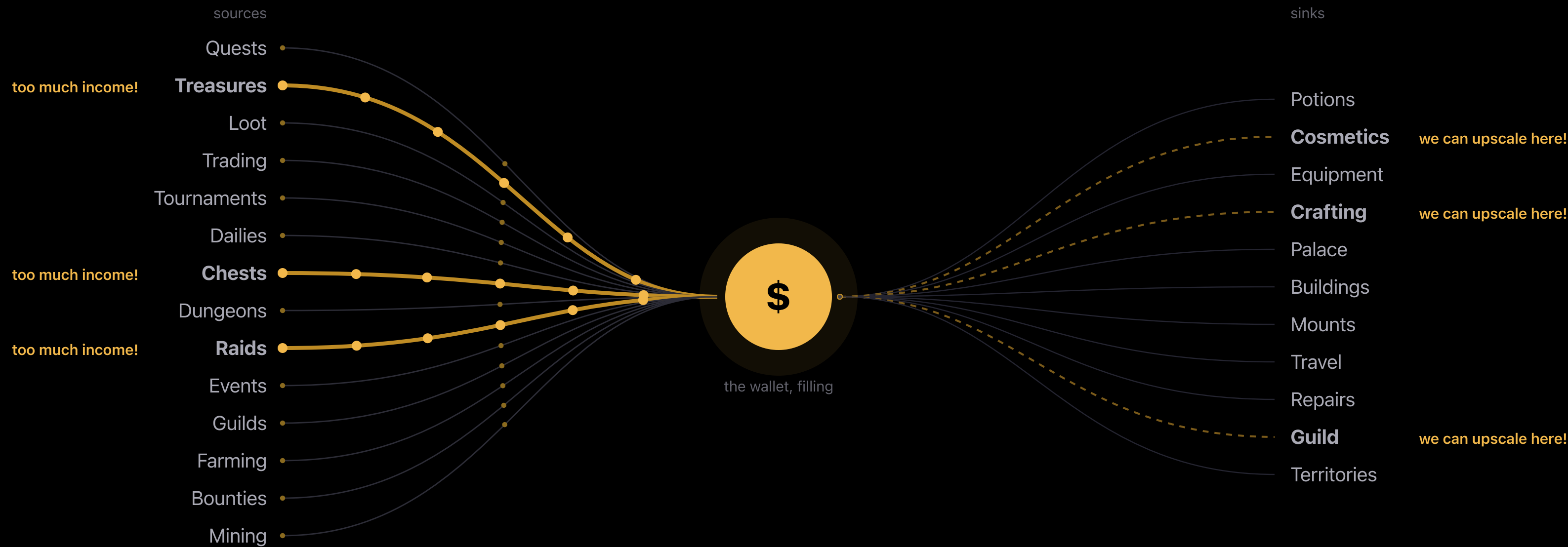
$\Delta \text{wallet} / \text{hour} = \text{sources} / \text{hour} - \text{sinks} / \text{hour}$



Rule 4

Kill inflation before it kills you

$\Delta \text{wallet} / \text{hour} = \text{sources} / \text{hour} - \text{sinks} / \text{hour}$



Whatever offer you show this player, they will not buy it. **They already have all the money in the world.** Cut the fattest source, widen the sink, add a rarer currency, overflow early and scarce late. None of it survives without a drain.

Rule 5

Basics of monetization

The order I build in, and why.

1 IAP + starter pack

No purchases means no funnel, no tests and no data. The starter pack is the fastest first conversion.

2 One rewarded placement in the hub

Monetizes the 95% who will never pay, without breaking the core loop.

3 Battle pass

Recurring revenue and a daily reason to come back.

4 Segmented offers

One price tag for a whale and a student is a mistake. Next slide.

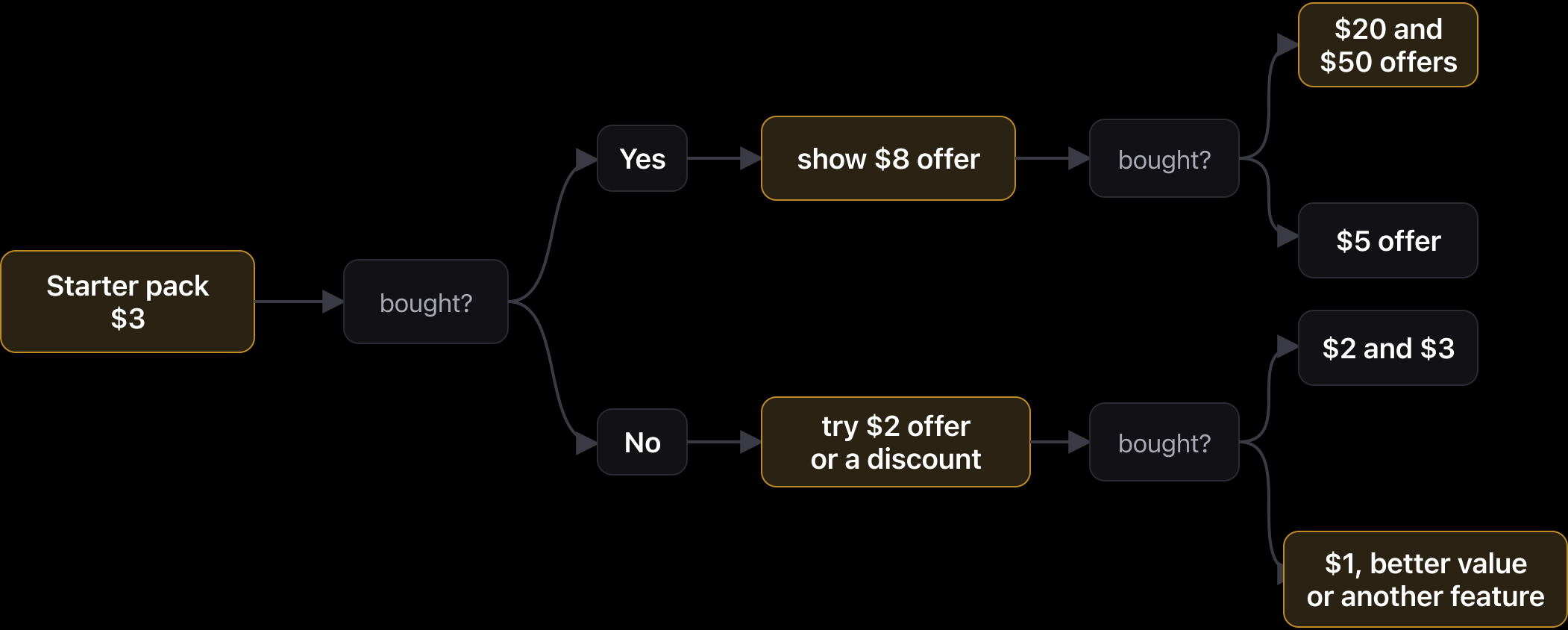
5 Personalized offers

The shop adapts the card to the player. Cap the generosity: the model does exactly what you optimized it for.

6 LiveOps calendar

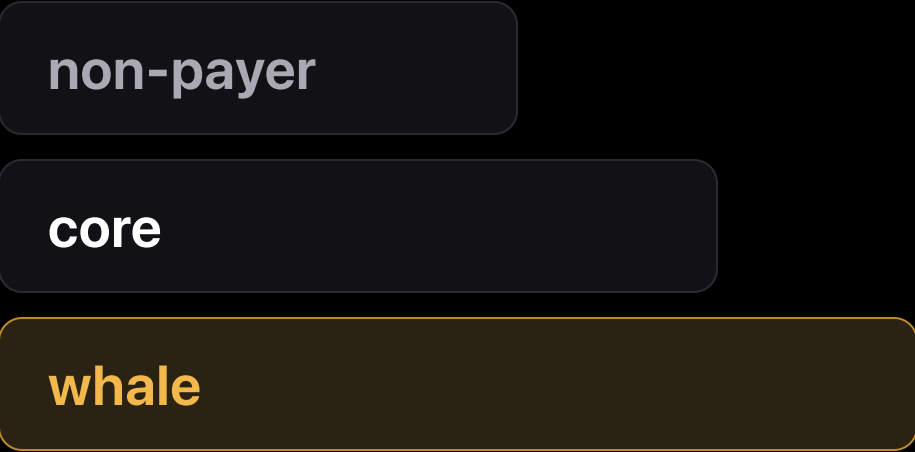
Isolated containers that always route back to the core loop.

Offer segmentation



and so on. Every price is an example.

The bare minimum, three tiers



- Offers refresh on the bought / declined trigger
- Revise the price ladder monthly, with A/B tests
- Every price here is an example. Adjust for your product.

Rule 5

Offer personalization

Rule 5

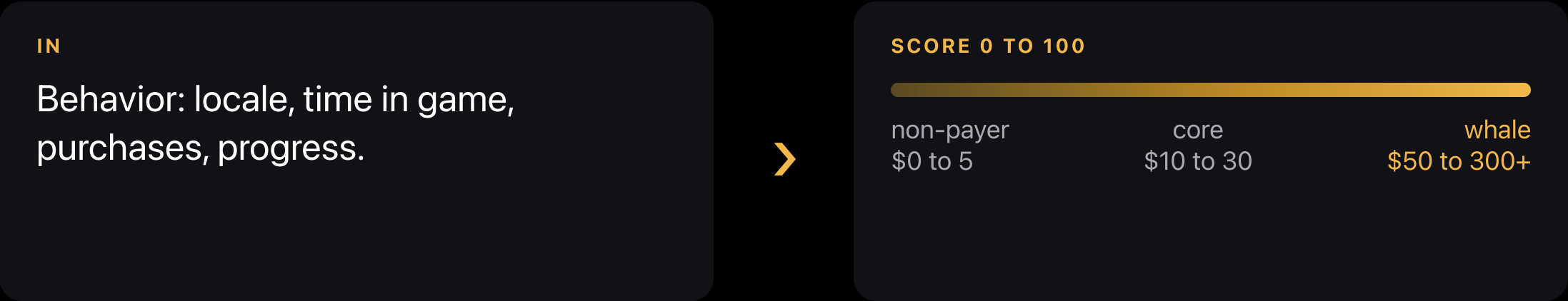
Offer personalization

IN

Behavior: locale, time in game,
purchases, progress.

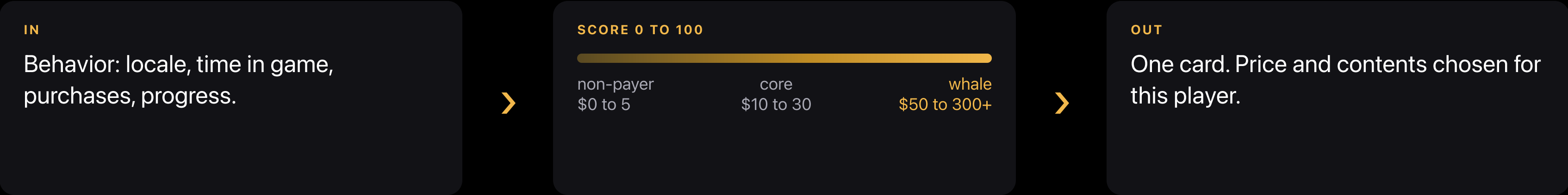
Rule 5

Offer personalization



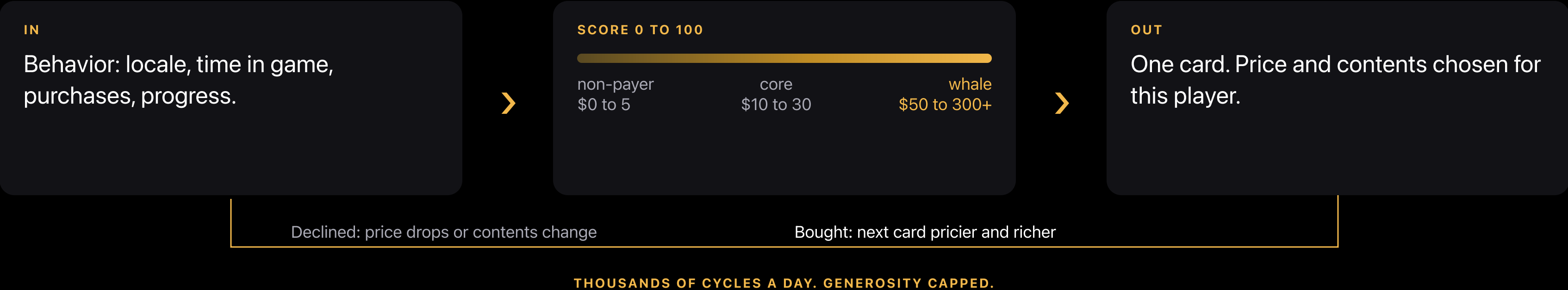
Rule 5

Offer personalization

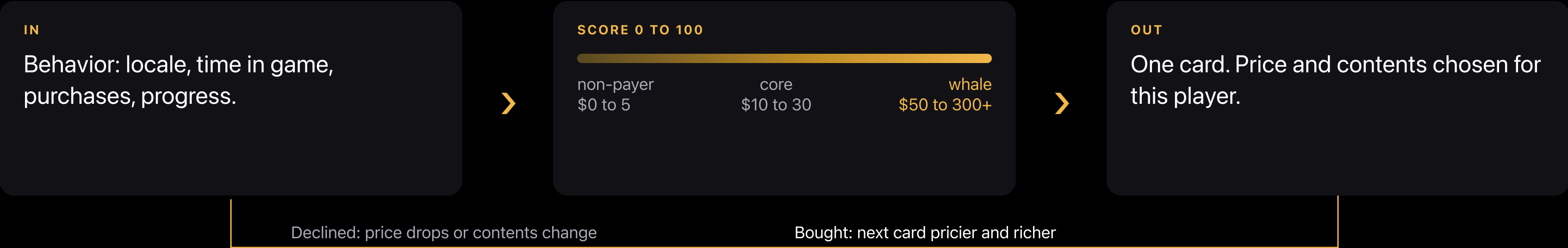


Rule 5

Offer personalization



Offer personalization



THOUSANDS OF CYCLES A DAY. GENEROSITY CAPPED.



Florescence, florist shop as a never-paid player sees it: three first-buy badges, €1.99, €5.99, €9.99. A whale sees other cards in these slots.

+41%

revenue after the shop started adapting the card to the player. Florescence, a merge game, with Balancy.

Rule 5

LiveOps

x2

LTV. **Frozen City** doubled revenue per download with events as the only lever.

x1.5

revenue. **Monopoly GO!**, the share AppMagic attributes to events.

89

event launches a month per top game in 2025.

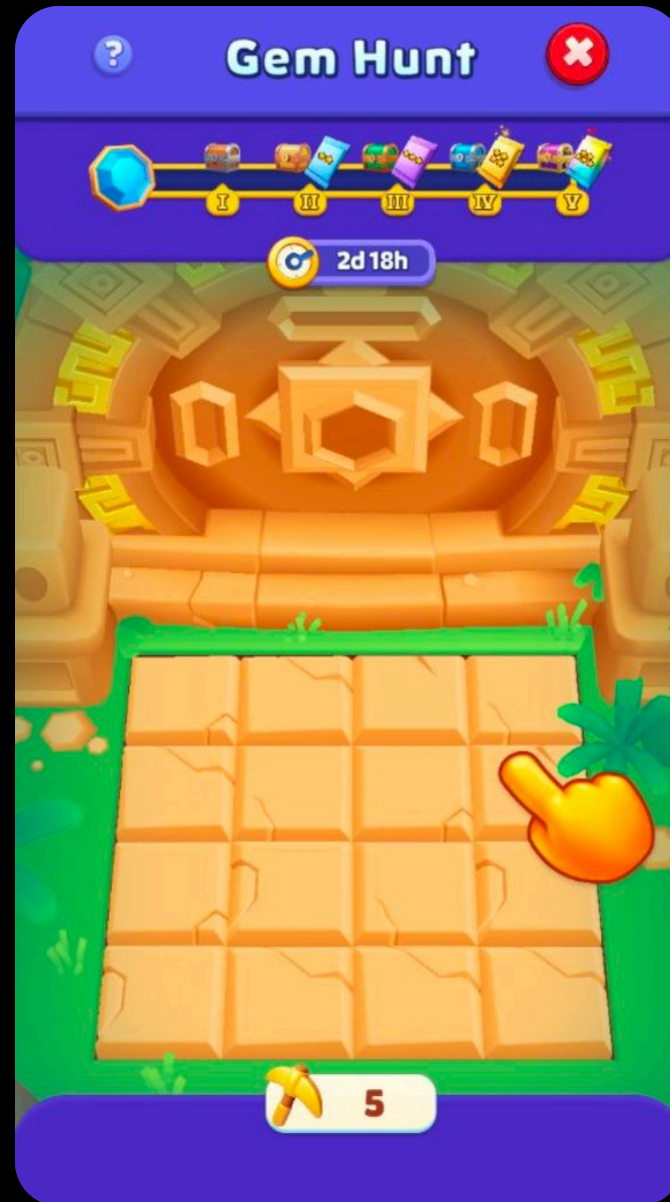


Every spike is an event. Merge Mansion, daily revenue against its LiveOps calendar, June 5 to September 2, 2026. Five launches, each +28 to +41% on the week.

One long LTV driver, two to ten short events a week. Isolated containers that end. Every event routes the player back to the core loop.

Rule 5

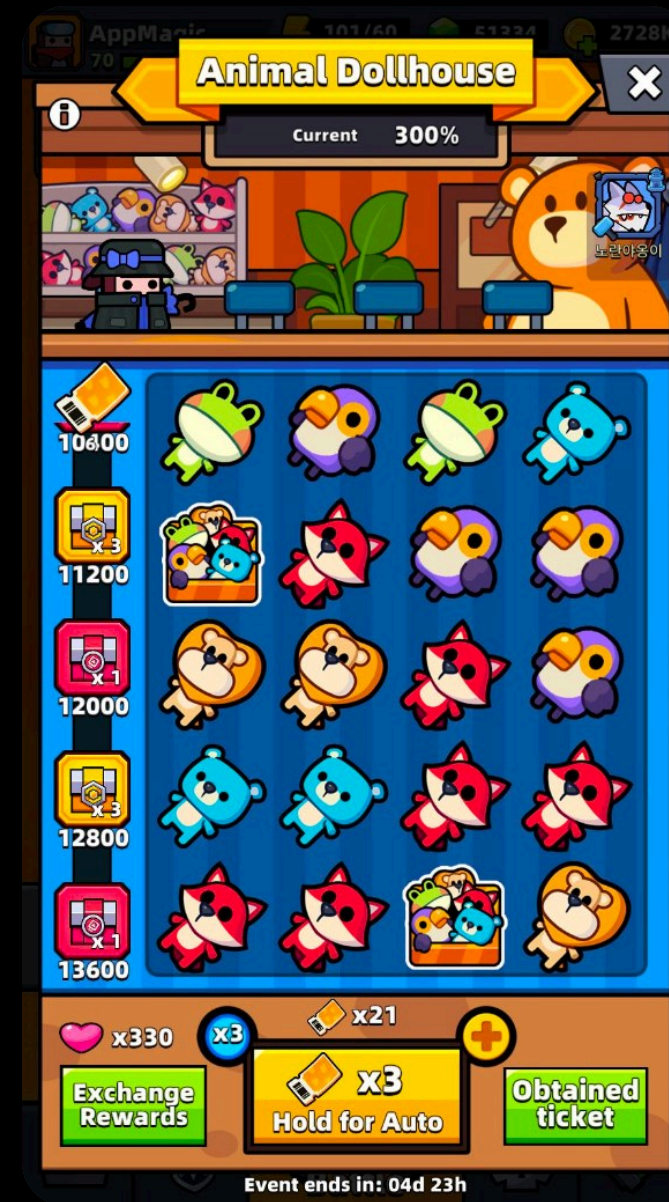
An event is a small game inside your game



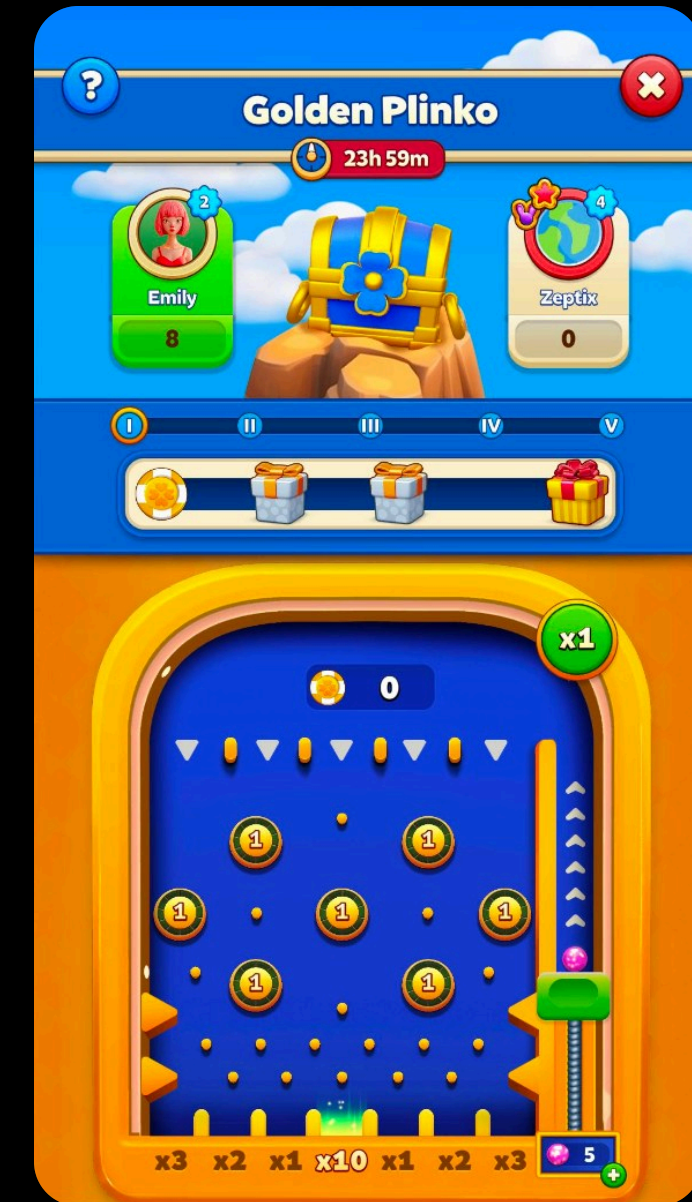
Digging



Board and dice



Collection

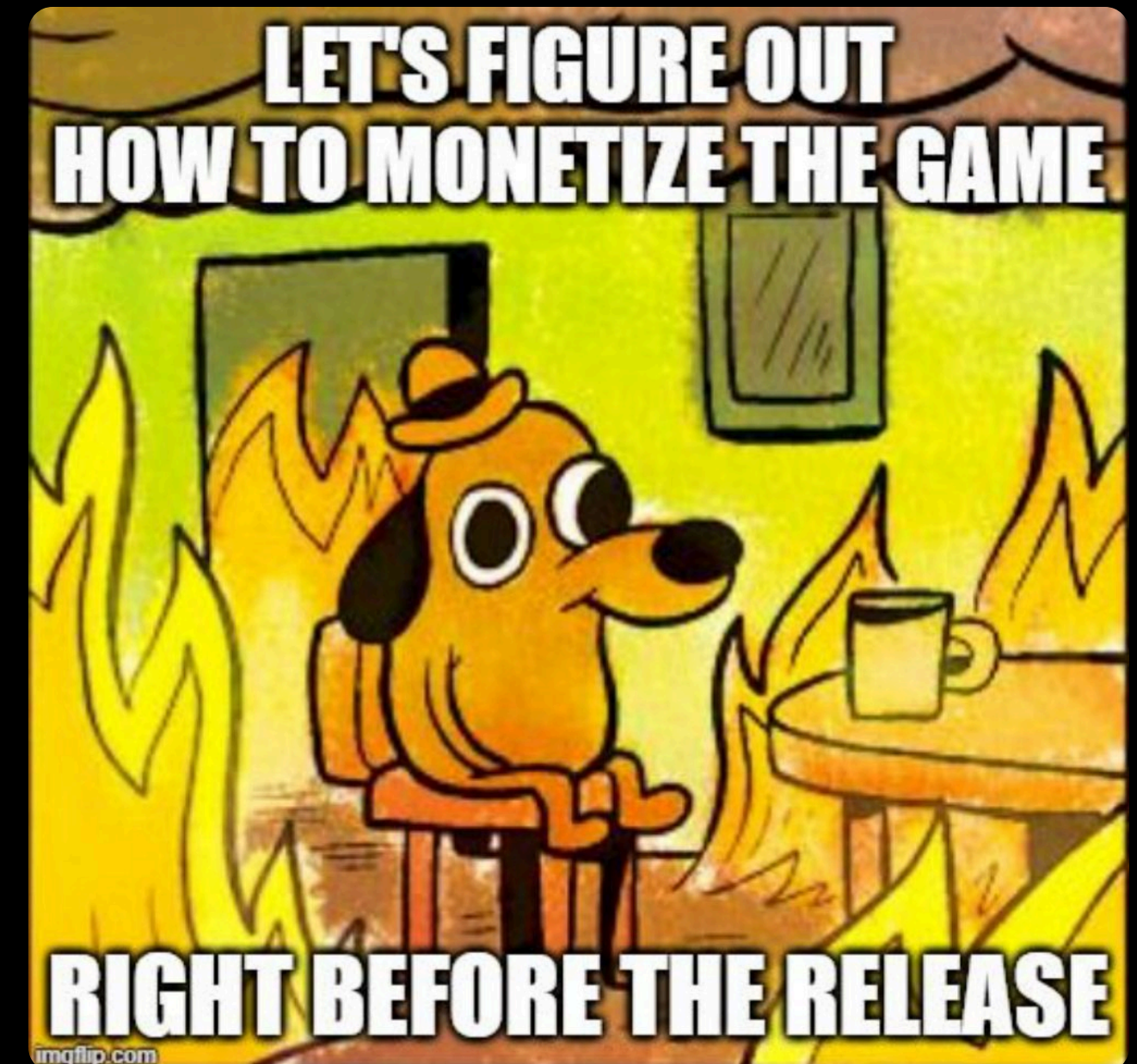


Plinko

Examples of trending events, 2025.

Five ways this goes wrong

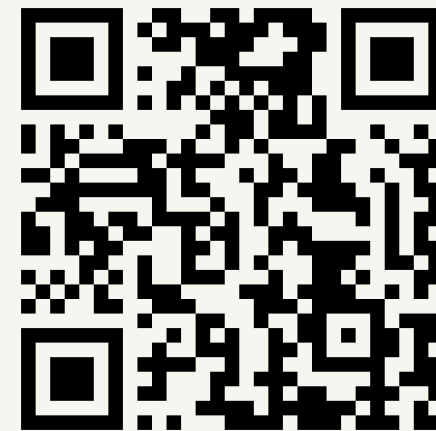
- 1 Monetization designed last**
it belongs in the GDD, not the postmortem
- 2 Pay-to-win over pay-for-fun**
people pay for speed and style, in every genre
- 3 A fountain with no drain**
too much is inflation, too little is frustration
- 4 One price for everybody**
- 5 A long road to the wallet**
anything over three taps



Every price in your game is a price in hours.



The handbook



Alex Wiserax on LinkedIn

Thank you